C2 Reading

Evaluating arguments: spotting weak reasoning

Read critically by identifying common flaws in reasoning, such as false cause, hasty generalisation and false choice.

At C2 you read not only for what a writer says but for how well they argue it. Persuasive texts can sound convincing while resting on weak logic. Naming the flaw helps you respond precisely, in discussion or in writing.

Flaw	What happens	Example
False cause	Assumes that because B followed A, A caused B	*Since the new manager arrived, sales have fallen. He's ruining the company.*
Hasty generalisation	Draws a big conclusion from a few cases	*Two of my friends hated the course, so it's clearly badly taught.*
False choice	Presents only two options when more exist	*Either we ban cars from the centre or we accept toxic air.*
Appeal to popularity	True because many people believe it	*Millions use this supplement, so it must work.*
Attacking the person	Criticises the speaker, not the argument	*Why listen to her views on tax? She's never run a business.*

Separate claim from evidence. Ask: what exactly is being claimed, what evidence is offered, and does the evidence actually lead to the claim? Weak arguments usually fail at the last step.

Common mistake. Assuming a flawed argument has a false conclusion. The manager might really be ruining the company; the point is that this reasoning doesn't prove it.

Read the text

> Schools that allow phones have lower exam results than those that ban them, so phones are clearly the cause of poor performance. Every teacher I've spoken to agrees. We must either ban phones completely or accept that our children will fail. Those who disagree are usually tech companies protecting their profits.

Practice

Name the flaw in each part of the text.

1. "...so phones are clearly the cause of poor performance."
2. "Every teacher I've spoken to agrees."
3. "We must either ban phones completely or accept that our children will fail."
4. "Those who disagree are usually tech companies protecting their profits."
5. Suggest one other factor that could explain the difference in results.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. False cause: correlation is treated as proof of cause.
2. Hasty generalisation: a small, unrepresentative sample.
3. False choice: other options exist, such as limited or supervised use.
4. Attacking the person: it questions motives instead of the argument.
5. For example: the schools may differ in funding, class size or students' backgrounds.